1.2 The QCAA Visual Art 2025 General Senior Syllabus

A summary for students and parents

Visual Art units

Students study four developmental units in Visual Art, and each unit builds on the skills and processes of the previous unit.

Each unit in the syllabus and the associated chapter in *Creative Inquiry* Second Edition is organised through a **concept** that directs students' learning in both **making** and **responding**. Concepts are further defined by a **focus**, which guides the selection of artists, artworks, art practices and learning experiences. The focus is teacher-directed in Units 1 and 2 and student-directed in Units 3 and 4. The four **contexts** – contemporary, personal, formal and cultural – are frames of reference that students will use to analyse and interpret artworks. Students foreground two contexts each in Units 1 and 2, and select their own contexts in Units 3 and 4. In Units 1 and 2, students engage with learning experiences across a range of two-dimensional, three-dimensional and time-based **media**, equipping them with knowledge and understanding to select their own media in Units 3 and 4.

concept *unit organisers that direct student learning and integrate making and responding; unit concepts engage students in learning experiences that allow them to develop their own focuses for artworks with an understanding of related artworks from a range of contexts*

making *working in the art form as artist using knowledge, skills, materials, techniques, technologies and processes to communicate ideas and intentions*

responding *writing or talking about art from the perspective of audience*

focus *individual student pathways that define interpretations and responses to the concepts; over the two-year course, the teacher will structure units of work emphasising a progression from teacher-directed focus, through teacher–student negotiated focus, to the students selecting and interpreting their own focus to resolve work*

contexts *frames of reference that inform the concepts and focuses, allowing intended and suggested meaning to evolve; these contexts include contemporary, personal, cultural and formal perspectives*

media *overviews of knowledge, skills, techniques and processes; each area should not be viewed as distinct or limited to preconceived understandings of the Visual Art discipline; media areas are not separate and multi/cross-media presentations should be encouraged*

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TABLE 1.1 THE DEVELOPMENTAL STRUCTURE OF THE FOUR UNITS

	Unit 1: Chapters 5 and 6	Unit 2: Chapters 7 and 8	Unit 3: Chapters 9 and 10	Unit 4: Chapters 11 and 12
Concept	**Art as lens**: lenses to explore the material world	**Art as code:** art as a coded visual language	**Body of work**	
			Art as knowledge: constructing knowledge as artist and audience	**Art as alternate:** evolving alternate representations and meaning
Context	• Personal • Contemporary	• Formal • Cultural	• Contemporary, personal, cultural and/or formal	• Contemporary • Personal, cultural and/or formal
Focus	People, place, objects	Codes, symbols, signs and art conventions	Student-directed	
Media	Two-dimensional, three-dimensional and time-based by the end of Unit 2		Student-selected	
	Making and responding			

Source: Visual Art 2025 v1.1 General Senior Syllabus © Queensland Curriculum & Assessment Authority

Objectives in Visual Art

All Queensland senior syllabuses have objectives that describe the learning in the subject and the cognitive or thinking processes required to be successful in the subject. The Visual Art **syllabus objectives** are:

1. **implement** ideas and representations
2. **apply** literacy skills
3. **analyse** and **interpret** visual language, expression and meaning in artworks and practices
4. **evaluate** influences
5. **justify** viewpoints
6. **experiment** in response to stimulus
7. **create** visual responses using knowledge and understanding of art media
8. **realise** responses to communicate meaning.

Syllabus objectives are used to inform the specific learning for **unit objectives** and how student work will be judged in **assessment objectives**. Teachers should provide opportunities for students to become familiar with the objectives and their meaning. You can find further explanation of the objectives and the cognitive processes in explanatory paragraphs in the Visual Art syllabus and throughout the chapters of *Creative Inquiry*.

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Syllabus objectives *outline what the school is required to teach and what students have the opportunity to learn; are described in terms of actions that operate on the subject matter; and are the overarching objectives for a course of study.*

unit objectives *drawn from the syllabus objectives and contextualised for the subject matter and requirements of a particular unit; they are assessed at least once in the unit*

assessment objectives *drawn from the unit objectives and contextualised for the requirements of the assessment instrument*

Cognitive processes in Visual Art objectives

The cognitive processes specific to Visual Art objectives are highlighted and defined below. Other subjects may also use these terms to describe cognitive processes. The terms and cognitive processes mean the same thing across different subjects.

implement *to start using a plan or system, to put ideas into effect, communicating meaning using images, words, objects and experiences.*

apply *use knowledge and understanding in response to a given situation or circumstance; carry out or use a procedure in a given or particular situation*

analyse *examine or consider something in order to explain and interpret it, for the purpose of finding meaning or relationships and identifying patterns, similarities and differences*

interpret *bring out the meaning of an artwork by artistic representation or performance; give one's own interpretation of*

evaluate *make an appraisal by weighing up or assessing strengths, implications and limitations; make judgements about ideas, works, solutions or methods in relation to selected criteria; examine and determine the merit, value or significance of something, based on criteria*

justify *give reasons or evidence to support an answer, response or conclusion; show or prove how an argument, statement or conclusion is right or reasonable*

experiment *try out or test new ideas or methods, especially in order to discover or prove something; undertake or perform a scientific procedure to test a hypothesis, make a discovery or demonstrate a known fact*

create *bring something into being or existence; produce or evolve from one's own thought or imagination; reorganise or put elements together into a new pattern or structure or to form a coherent or functional whole*

realise *create or make (e.g. a musical, artistic or dramatic work); actualise; make real or concrete; give reality or substance to*

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Assessment in Visual Art

Visual Art assessment in Units 1 and 2 is **formative**. This means it is designed to give students feedback on their progress as a Visual Art student. Unit 1 and 2 assessment is designed by teachers to suit your school context and give students opportunities to experience the types of assessment required in Units 3 and 4.

Visual Art assessment in Units 3 and 4 is **summative**. This means that students' grades will contribute towards their final subject result. There are four summative assessments in senior subjects. The four summative assessments in Visual Art are shown in Table 1.2.

All summative assessment instruments, their specifications and conditions are fully described in the Visual Art syllabus, which should be referred to for specific summative internal and **external assessment** information.

The external assessment is created and marked by the Queensland Curriculum and Assessment Authority (QCAA). All Visual Art students will complete the same external assessment at the same time.

Internal assessments respond to a **stimulus** selected by the teacher to suit the school context. It is important to understand that the internal assessment instruments build on this stimulus and each other to resolve one **body of work**. This approach is unique to Visual Art.

The QCAA creates resources, such as sample student responses that demonstrate assessment requirements. *Creative Inquiry* includes many student examples.

formative assessment *assessment whose major purpose is to improve teaching and student achievement*

summative assessment *assessment whose major purpose is to indicate student achievement; summative assessments contribute towards a student's subject result*

external assessment *summative assessment that occurs towards the end of a course of study and is common to all schools; developed and marked by the QCAA according to a commonly applied marking scheme*

stimulus *resource materials used in assessment activities to elicit a response from the student*

body of work *consists of individual student responses to making and responding to tasks that integrate concept, focus, context and media area/s; may lead to a single work or a collection of works, related to each other in some way, with each one being as important as the other*

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TABLE 1.2 VISUAL ART SUMMATIVE ASSESSMENT

Assesses processes learned in:		Instrument	Type	Title	Contribution
Unit 3	**Body of work**	Summative internal assessment 1 (IA1)	Investigation	Inquiry phase 1	20%
		Summative internal assessment 2 (IA2)	Project	Inquiry phase 2	25%
Unit 4		Summative internal assessment 3 (IA3)	Project	Inquiry phase 3	30%
Units 3 and 4		Summative external assessment	Extended response		25%

Source: Adapted from Visual Art 2025 v1.1 General Senior Syllabus © Queensland Curriculum & Assessment Authority

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